ASSEMBLY POLLS 2023
CHHATTISGARH

THE PATIENT CRUSADER

WILL FORTUNE FINALLY TURN FOR SURGUJA'S EX-MAHARAJA, T.S. SINGH DEO, WHO CONTINUES TO BE A CM HOPEFUL?

By Rahul Noronha



UBESH MANSURI

POLL BUGLE T.S. Singh Deo in Mungeli, Nov. 6

Tribhuvaneshwar Saran Singh Deo, 71, the deputy chief minister of Chhattisgarh, recalls the time when he used to accompany his father on hunts, sitting at water holes, waiting for the quarry to arrive. The experience, says Singh Deo—or Baba as the 'Maharaja' of the erstwhile princely state of Surguja is fondly called—instilled in him a desirable virtue: patience.

It was this patience that saw him through a rough patch when his party, the Congress, purportedly failed to honour the promise of rotational chief ministership and even the local administration stopped responding to his requests, given his then strained relationship with Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel. It was only in June this year that Singh Deo was elevated as deputy CM, as the Congress set out to put its house in order in the central Indian state.

It's the election season in Chhattisgarh, and Singh Deo is barnstorming down the state in a chopper, addressing one public meeting after another. After landing at the Darima airstrip on the outskirts of Ambikapur—the capital of the erstwhile Surguja state—the ex-royal gets behind the wheel while exiting the terminal in a car. "As a student, first at The Scindia School in Gwalior and then at Delhi University, we would come to Ambikapur only during the holidays, and most of our time was spent outdoors," recalls Singh Deo, who has won the Ambikapur assembly seat thrice in a row since 2008. "Politics happened much later, even though my mother, the late Devendra Kumari, had been a minister in undivided Madhya Pradesh in the 1970s."

Downplaying his royal background, Singh Deo maintains that the Congress has always been socialist in its outlook. "We have known that throughout," he says, "and joined it because it is a very accommodating party that takes people from all backgrounds along."

And taking along his partymen, Singh Deo played a crucial role in the Congress win in 2018, even if the high command ended up choosing Baghel over him. With the Congress showing no signs of making him CM—he claims a rotational arrangement was promised, something that the party has never denied—there came a time, just about a year ago, when he in fact decided to retire from politics. "I want to be a productive asset if I am in government," he says. "I don't want to be there just for the sake of holding on to a post."

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Ask him if, in the season of changing loyalties, joining another party is an option, and Singh Deo points to his long association with the Congress. "You know, during the Janata Party government when the Congress (I) was formed, there were six people who had joined it in Ambikapur. The recruitment in-charge in the town would complain that no one is coming forward. That's when I filled in the membership form and joined the party," he says, making it clear that he would never think of jettisoning the Congress.

However, as he goes about campaigning, making promises and targeting the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), what's missing is Singh Deo's camaraderie with Baghel that was on display ahead of the historic win in 2018. In case the Congress wins another term, both of them suggest that the party high command will decide on the leadership responsibilities. Will patience pay off for the 'Maharaja' finally? ■